SC, ST and OBC students at the IISERs

A data study from NIRF 2018 to 2026 · iGEM IISER Kolkata 2026 · Inclusivity ·

Background

Nationally, SC, ST and OBC students are well represented at entry to higher education but their share falls at the PhD stage [2]. The IISERs admit through a common process and are national institutes, so who is in the classroom at each of them is a fair question to put to public data.

Aims

To describe, from the figures the institutes report to NIRF, what share of students come from SC, ST and OBC communities, how this differs between institutes, how it has changed, and what the data cannot tell us.

Results

- Taken together, the seven IISERs report 47.6% of students from SC, ST and OBC communities (4,418 of 9,276, latest year for each). The range is 40.3% (Berhampur) to 52.9% (Tirupati). Kolkata is 47.0%; IISc is 49.7%.
- This is close to the 49.5% that central reservation sets aside for these three groups [3], and close to the 46.3% for all Institutes of National Importance [2]. It is well below the 62.9% these groups make up of undergraduate enrolment in India [2]. Berhampur's latest figure looks like a change in reporting (see below).
- Pune's share has fallen steadily, from 49.5% to 45.1% (−0.8 points a year, 95% interval −1.0 to −0.5). No other institute shows a trend we can distinguish from zero. Kolkata is flat (−0.1 a year, interval −0.6 to +0.5).
- At each of the five IISERs that report both, the share in postgraduate programmes is lower than in undergraduate programmes: 41.6% against 49.2% pooled. The gap is largest at Tirupati. This compares different admission routes, not the same students over time.
- The share of students from the institute's own state is unrelated to this share across institutes (rank correlation -0.19, n = 8), so "more local students" does not explain the differences.
- We cannot say how SC and ST students do on their own, because OBC (27 of the 49.5 points of reservation) can fill the combined number by itself. We also cannot report PhD students by category, and faculty by category only for Kolkata.
- At Kolkata, 21 of 131 faculty (16.0%, interval 10.7% to 23.3%) are from reserved categories, against 47.0% of students. All 7 appointments in the latest hiring cycle were from reserved categories, which moved the share up by about 5 points. Details by group are in Section 7.

Introduction

Our other two studies ask who is missing in terms of gender: among students and among faculty. This one asks the same question about social background. In India, admission to central institutions reserves seats for Scheduled Castes (15%), Scheduled Tribes (7.5%) and Other Backward Classes (27%) [3]. Together that is 49.5% of seats, and we use it below as a reference line, not as a target or a judgement.

The question is whether the people in the room reflect that. National data show that SC and ST shares hold up at undergraduate level but fall at the PhD [2]. NIRF, the ranking framework every institute fills in each year, reports one number for students from these groups. We collected it for every IISER and for IISc.

A word on what this can and cannot show: Reporting what share of students come from these communities is a count of presence. It does not say how any of them experience the institute, and it says nothing about individuals. We avoid language that implies more than the numbers do.

Our dataset

We used the "Total Actual Student Strength" table in 44 NIRF submissions (the institutes' own declarations to the Ministry of Education): Kolkata 2019–2026, Pune 2019–2026, Mohali 2019–2025, TVM 2020–2026, Berhampur 2024–2026, Tirupati 2025–2026, Bhopal 2026 and IISc 2018 and 2020–2026. This gave 79 programme rows. The table lists, for each programme, total students and, among them, those who are "Socially Challenged (SC+ST+OBC, including male and female)". A NIRF year Y reports students for the academic year (Y−2) to (Y−1), so NIRF 2026 means 2024-25.

The table covers undergraduate (UG) and postgraduate (PG) programmes. It does not cover PhD students, and it gives no category split by gender. The share we report is the combined SC, ST and OBC count divided by total students.

Reference line. 49.5% is the sum of the reserved seat shares. A student from these groups who wins an open-category seat is probably counted in the NIRF figure as well, so the reported share can legitimately sit above 49.5%.

Key findings

1. Where each institute stands

Shares in the latest year lie between 40.3% and 52.9% (Figure 1). Kolkata's 47.0% (559 of 1189) has an interval of 44.2% to 49.9%, which includes the 49.5% line. Pune (45.1%) and Berhampur (40.3%) are clearly below it, and Tirupati (52.9%) is above it. Across the seven IISERs the differences are larger than chance would give ($\chi^2 = 43.4$, 6 degrees of freedom, $p < 0.001$), so the institutes are not all the same.

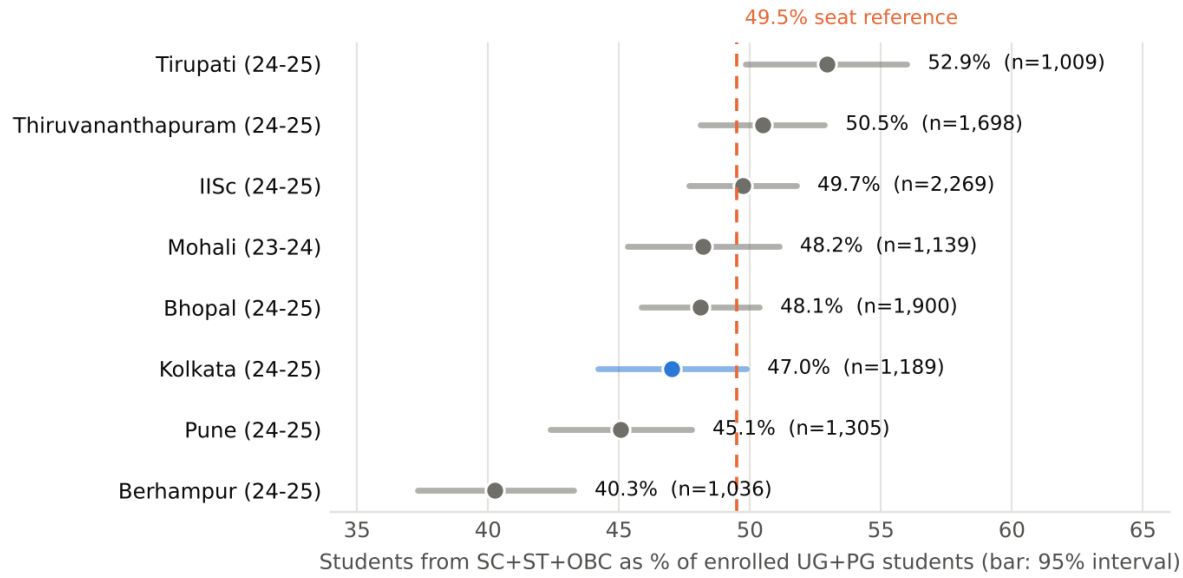


Figure 1: Share of students from SC, ST and OBC communities, latest year. Dots show the share; bars are 95% intervals. The dashed line is the 49.5% reservation reference. The year in brackets is the academic year of the data. Source: NIRF student tables.

Berhampur's share was 47.1% and 48.7% in the two earlier years, and 40.3% in the latest, while the institute added 183 students: the number of SC, ST and OBC students rose by only 2 (415 to 417). Some students leave each year, so this is not the category mix of the new entrants, but a rise of 2 against 183 is hard to reconcile with admission under reservation. In the same year its "economically backward" count rose from 10% to 37% of students. This looks more like a change in how the table was filled in than a change in who was admitted. If we use its previous figure, the seven-institute pool is 48.6% instead of 47.6%. We have not removed it, but anyone quoting the pooled figure should say this.

2. What the shares mean against a benchmark

Figure 2 sets the IISERs against national figures from AISHE, the Ministry's survey of all higher education [2]. The AISHE figures cover all levels including PhD, and define the groups slightly differently, so differences of a few points are not meaningful. Two things stand out. The IISER pool (47.6%) and IISc (49.7%) sit with the Institutes of National Importance (46.3%) and with all universities (49.8%). All of these are well below the 62.9% these groups make up of undergraduate enrolment across India. Institutes with national entrance tests draw from the whole country, so lower shares than the national UG figure are expected, but that is a hypothesis, not a finding.

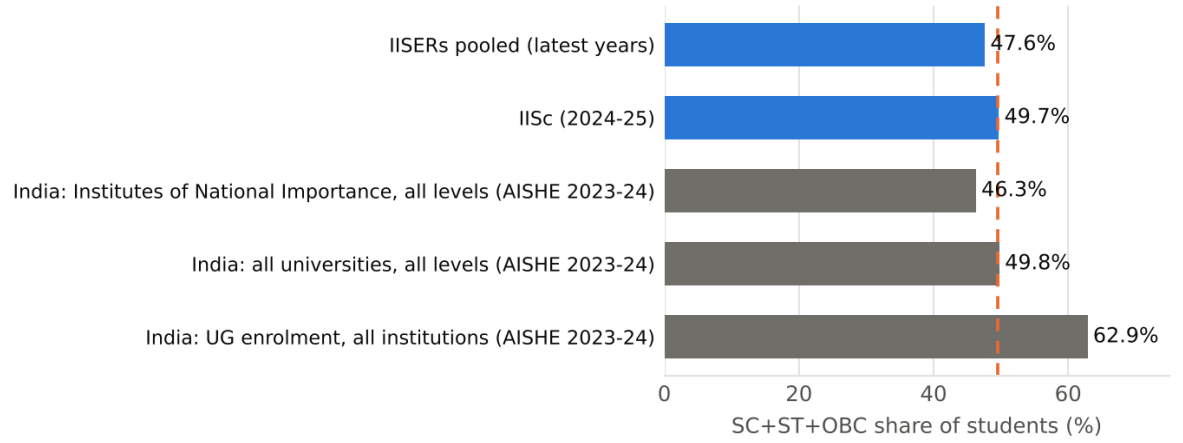


Figure 2: Share of SC, ST and OBC students, IISERs compared with national figures. IISER and IISc bars are NIRF (latest year). Grey bars are AISHE 2023-24 [2]. Dashed line: 49.5% seat reference.

In numbers of people, the latest-year gap to a 49.5% share is about 174 students across the seven IISERs (96 of them at Berhampur, 58 at Pune and 30 at Kolkata; Figure 3). It is an illustration of scale: Tirupati, TVM and IISc are above the line. It is not a target and not a count of people who were turned away.

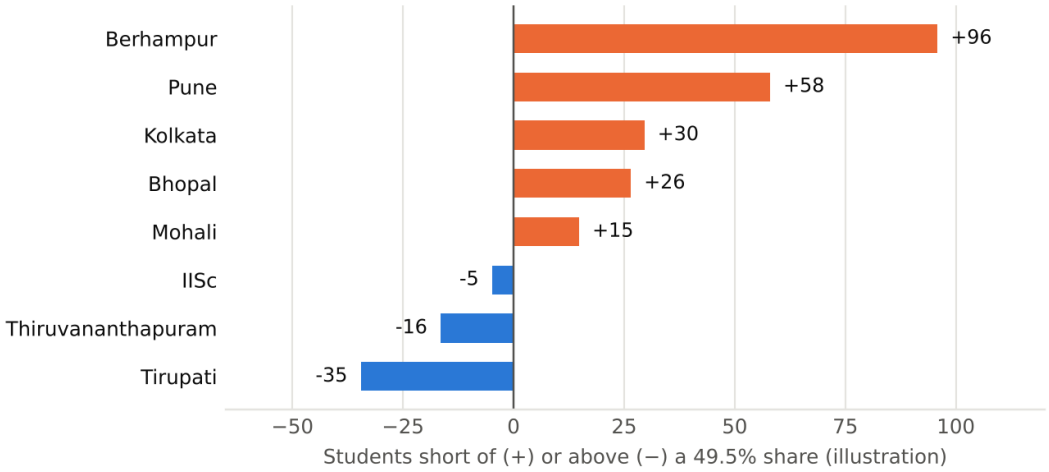
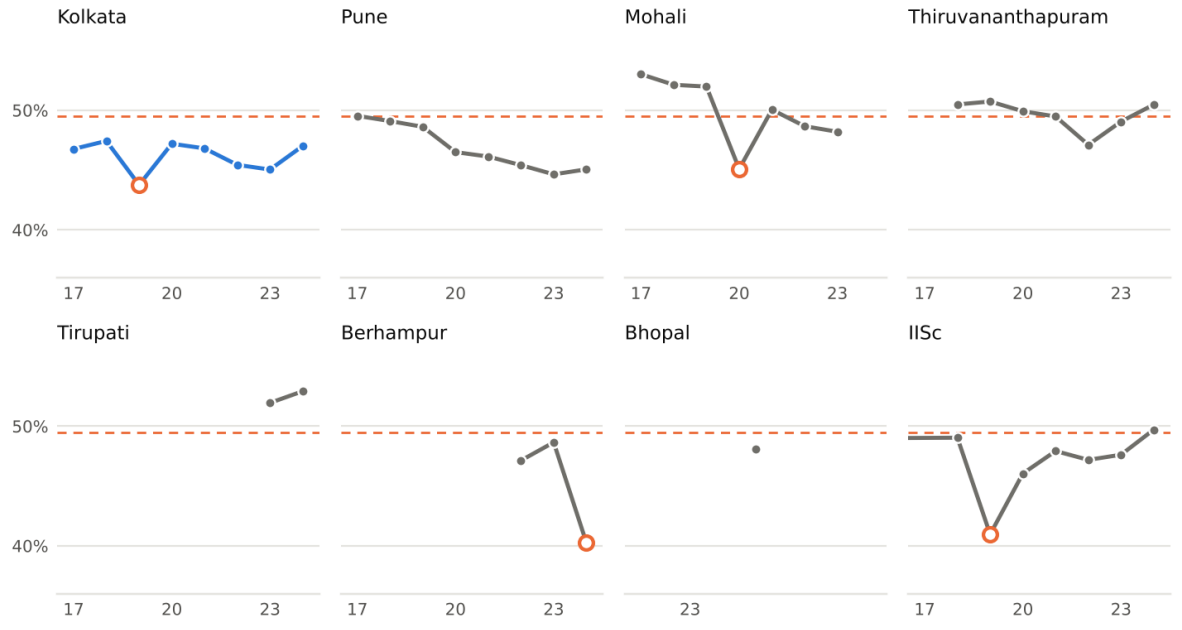


Figure 3: Students short of, or above, a 49.5% share. Latest year for each institute. Positive means fewer students than a 49.5% share would give.

3. How the share has changed

Figure 4 shows each institute over time. Pune is the one clear trend: the share fell almost every year, from 49.5% (2017-18) to 45.1% (2024-25), about 0.8 points a year, and the interval for the slope does not include zero (Figure 5). Kolkata, TVM, Mohali and IISc show no trend we can tell from zero. Across all five institutes with a long series, the average change is −0.3 points a year, but without Pune it is −0.17 and no longer distinguishable from zero.



Start of data year (2017 = 2017-18). Dashed: 49.5%. Hollow orange: share moved >3 points in one year; check.

Figure 4: SC+ST+OBC share by institute over time. Each panel shows one institute. Hollow orange points mark a one-year move of more than 3 points, which we treat as a possible reporting change (Appendix B).

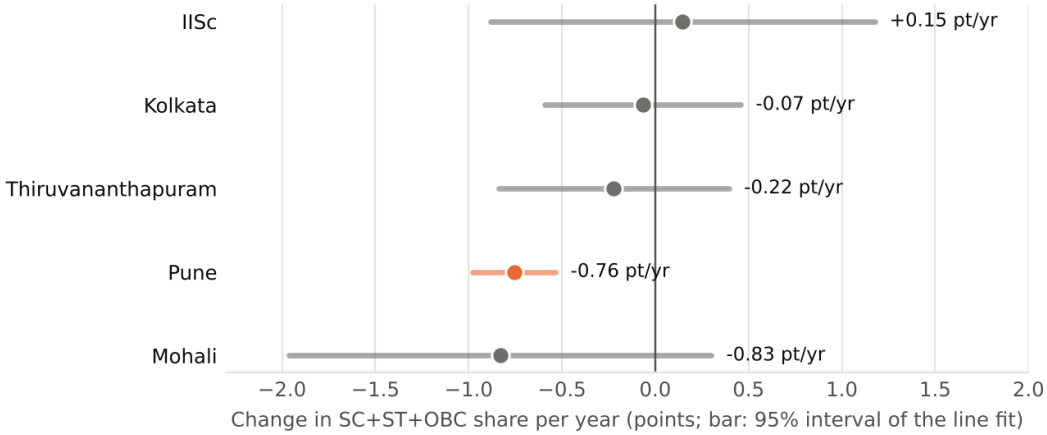


Figure 5: Yearly change in the SC+ST+OBC share. Slope of a straight line through each institute's series, with its 95% interval. Pune only is clearly below zero. Intervals assume independent years; the students overlap across years, so true uncertainty is larger.

What could explain Pune? The data cannot say. Candidates are a change in the mix of admission routes over these years (for example, the end of the KVPY route and the start of the IAT), growth in intake, or the way the institute classifies students. Each would show up differently in admissions data by route and category, which the institute holds and NIRF does not report. We therefore treat Pune's decline as a question for the institute, not a conclusion.

4. Undergraduate against postgraduate

At the five IISERs that report both UG and PG students, the SC, ST and OBC share is lower in PG at every one (Figure 6). Pooled, it is 41.6% in PG (231 of 555) against 49.2% in UG (3,221 of 6,546) for the same five institutes. The gap is mostly at Tirupati (29% against 55%); without Tirupati, it is about 4 points and the evidence is weaker ($p = 0.06$). All five lie in the same direction, but five institutes are too few to call it a pattern, and the PG programmes are small ($n = 73$ to 162 each).

This is a comparison of admission routes into different programmes, not of the same students over time. The AISHE data show a step down at the PhD [2]; the IISER data cannot yet show whether it begins earlier.

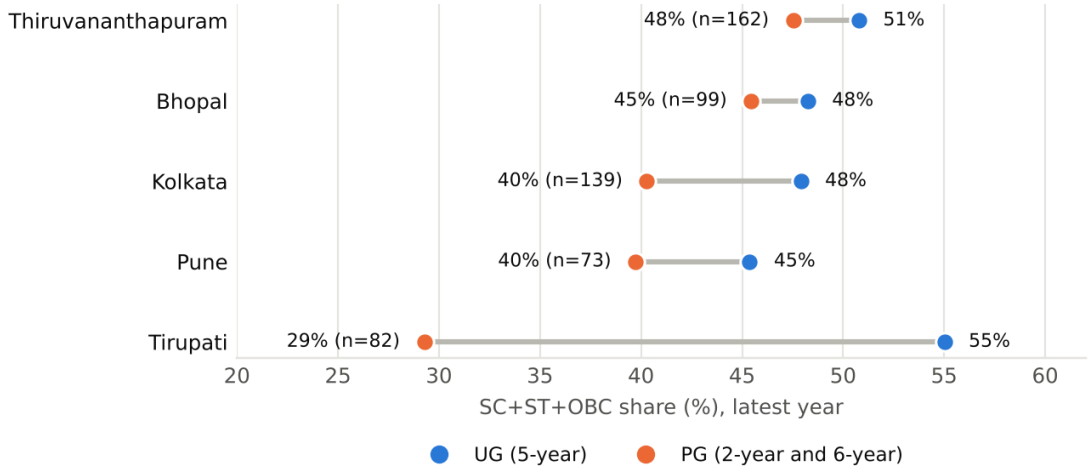


Figure 6: SC+ST+OBC share in UG and PG programmes. Latest year, five IISERs that report PG students. Orange: PG (2-year and 6-year programmes); blue: UG 5-year programme. n is PG students.

5. Does the home state explain it?

We checked whether institutes with more students from their own state have higher or lower shares. They do not (Figure 7; rank correlation -0.19, p = 0.65, n = 8). Kolkata and TVM both take over 40% of students from their home state but sit on opposite sides of the reference line; Mohali, Bhopal and Tirupati take under 10% and are on both sides too. With eight points this can only rule out a strong relationship.

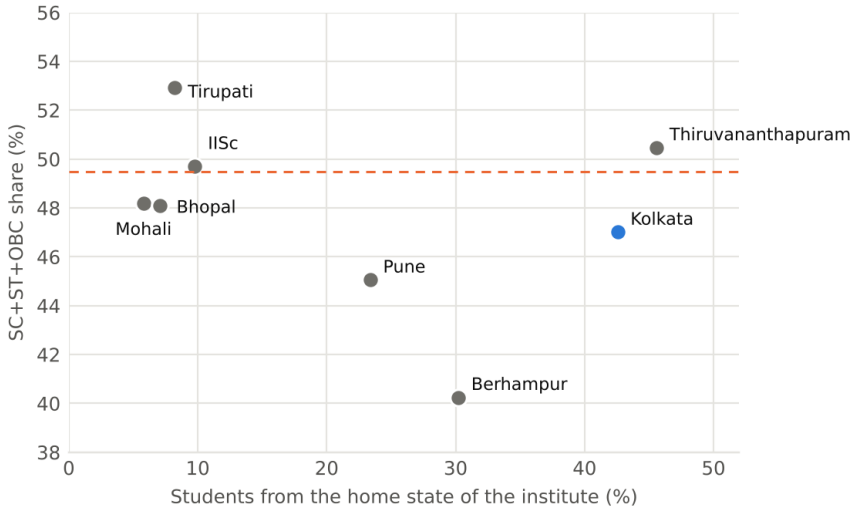


Figure 7: Home-state share and SC+ST+OBC share across institutes. Latest year; each dot is an institute. Dashed line: 49.5%.

6. A data-quality warning: the "economically backward" column

The same table has an "Economically Backward" column. We looked at it and did not use it. At Kolkata it reads 15%, 12%, 28%, 27%, 35%, 9%, 9%, 10% in successive years; at TVM it is 0% in two years; at Berhampur it jumps from 10% to 37% in one year (Figure 8). Since the data follows no reliable trend, we refrain from using it as solid evidence. The SC+ST+OBC column is steadier, but seven institute-years

move by more than 3 points in a single year, which is hard to explain through admissions alone (Appendix B).

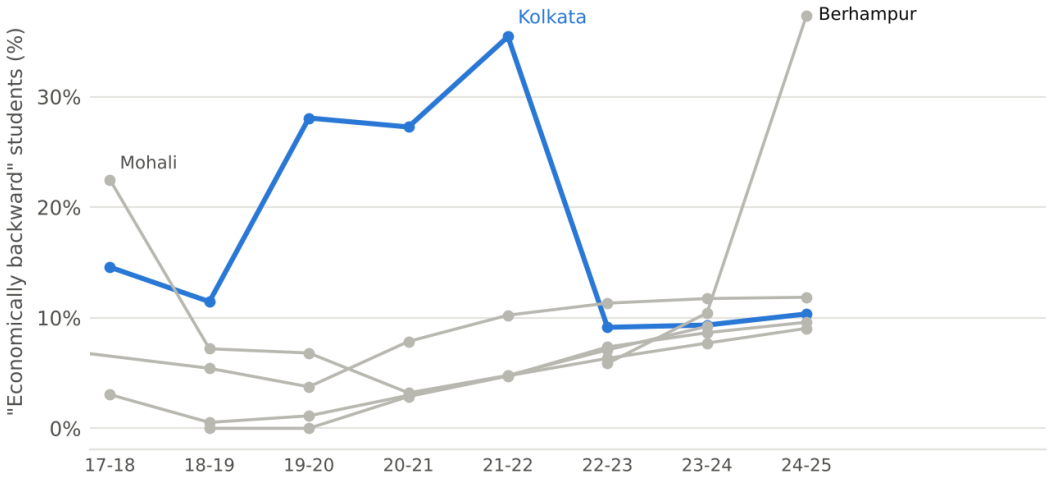


Figure 8: Reported "economically backward" students, % of all students. Each line is an institute; Kolkata in blue. The swings suggest inconsistent definitions, so we do not interpret this column.

7. Faculty at IISER Kolkata (figures supplied by the institute)

NIRF has no category column for faculty, so for faculty we rely on figures the institute gave us: 110 faculty from the general category, 8 from SC, 12 from OBC and 1 from ST, 131 in all. The institute's count excludes the director. Of the 7 appointments in the most recent hiring cycle, all were from reserved categories; 4 are men and 3 are women.

Reserved-category faculty are 21 of 131, or 16.0% (95% interval 10.7% to 23.3%). By group: SC 8 (6.1%), ST 1 (0.8%), OBC 12 (9.2%). Against the reservation reference points, SC is under half of 15%, OBC about a third of 27% and ST far below 7.5% (Figure 9). The student body at Kolkata is 47.0% from these groups, so the share falls by about 31 points from the classroom to the faculty (Figure 10). This resembles the national step down from UG to PhD [2], but the two comparisons are not the same measure: the faculty figure is a stock built over many years, including appointments made before reservation in faculty posts applied in the same form.

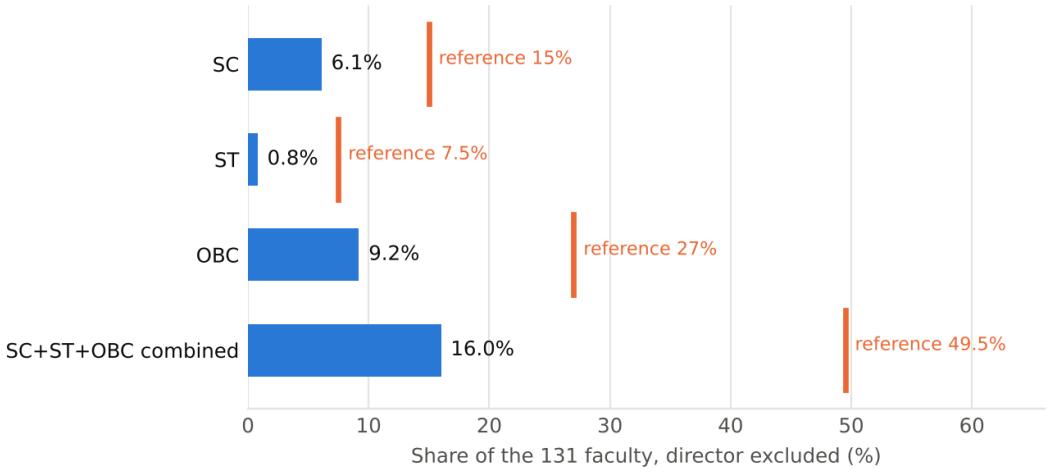


Figure 9: Reserved-category faculty at IISER Kolkata, by group. Bars show the share of all 131 faculty. Orange marks are the reservation reference points (15% SC, 27% OBC, 49.5% combined). Source: institute figures supplied to the team; the director is excluded.

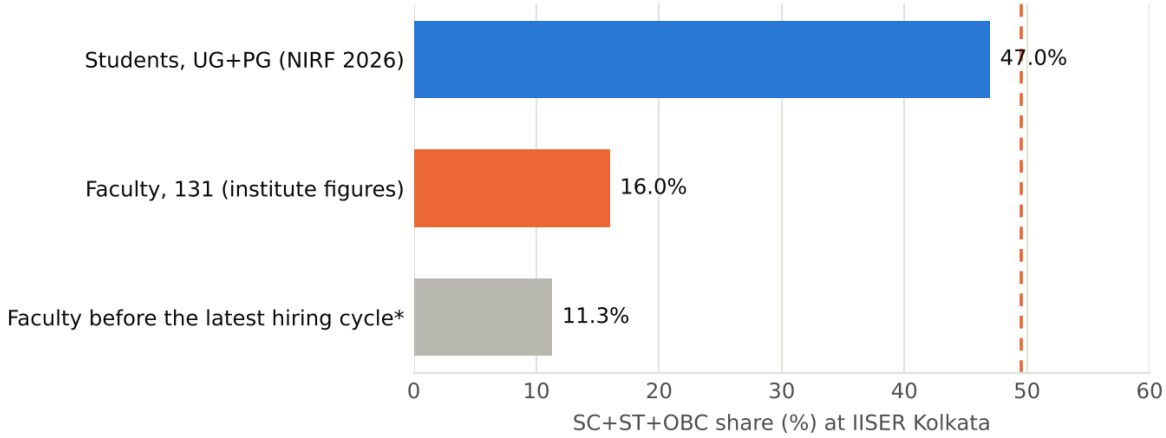


Figure 10: Students and faculty at IISER Kolkata, SC+ST+OBC share. Student figure from NIRF 2026 (2024-25). Faculty figures from the institute. *The 131 includes the 7 appointments of the latest cycle, so the earlier figure is 14 of 124. Dashed line: 49.5%.

The latest hiring cycle matters here, but should be read carefully. Seven of seven appointments from reserved categories raised the share by about 5 points (from 11.3% to 16.0% if these 7 are among the 131). That is a large step for one cycle and is consistent with posts being filled in line with reserved vacancies. It is still seven people. It does not by itself show a change in practice, and a single cycle cannot give a trend. As a rough illustration of pace, if the next cycles were also entirely from reserved categories at 7 a year, the share would reach about 30% after four more cycles; at the 49.5% reference rate of hiring it would move more slowly. This is arithmetic, not a forecast.

The 131 reconciles with NIRF 2026. NIRF lists 125 regular faculty, including the director. The institute's count excludes the director, which leaves 124, and the 7 appointments of the latest cycle are not yet in NIRF (they are not in the 2026 submission). 124 + 7 = 131. This assumes nobody has left since the submission. Our other two studies count NIRF regular faculty including the director, so the director should be removed from those series too for consistency.

Three of the 7 new appointments are women. Before them, 8 of 59 appointments since 2013 were women (14%), against 22% at the other six IISERs. Adding the 3 makes it 11 of 66 (16.7%), still below 22%, and

the difference remains one we cannot tell from chance (p = 0.42). Three of seven is a small group. We do not publish the cross-tabulation of gender and category for the 7.

Our Inferences

Read together, we interpret the following picture from the findings:

- **The combined share is near the reservation reference.** Across the IISERs and IISc it is 45% to 53%, and Kolkata is within its margin of the 49.5% line. On this number alone there is no obvious shortfall, apart from Berhampur (probably a reporting change) and Pune.
- **The combined number hides the groups that matter most.** OBC makes up 27 of the 49.5 reserved points. An institute can reach the reference through OBC students alone while SC and ST students are far below their 15% and 7.5%. Nationally ST students are 6.3% of UG enrolment [2]; we do not know the figure at any IISER. This is the most important thing the NIRF data cannot show.
- **Two patterns merit an interesting observation.** Pune's steady drift down, and lower shares in PG programmes at all five institutes where both exist.
- **Faculty sit well below students at Kolkata.** Reserved-category faculty are 16.0% of 131 against 47.0% of students, SC at 6.1%, ST at 0.8% and OBC at 9.2%. All 7 recent appointments were from reserved categories, which is a visible step but one cycle. The other IISERs have no faculty figures yet, and PhD students by category are still missing.

Methods and limits

- **Counts are stocks, not cohorts.** A 5-year programme's student body is five admission cohorts. A year's share moves slowly, so a jump of more than a few points in one year is more likely a reporting change than a change in admissions.
- **Intervals and p-values are descriptive.** We treat students as independent draws within a year, but the same students appear in several years and institutes differ in many ways. We treat the intervals as a lower bound on the uncertainty.
- **One institute-year is one declaration.** Institutes fill in NIRF themselves. We checked row totals (male + female = total; home state + other state = total) and they hold in all 79 rows, but we cannot check the category counts against any other source.
- **Years vary.** The latest year is 2024-25 for all institutes except Mohali (2023-24, since its 2026 file was not available). Bhopal and Tirupati have one and two years.
- **Group comparisons use small samples.** PG programmes have 73 to 162 students at each institute.
- **The Kolkata faculty figures are institute-supplied.** They exclude the director.
- **No causal claims.** The data describe how many students from these groups are enrolled; they do not show why numbers differ.

Literature

[1] National Institutional Ranking Framework (NIRF), Ministry of Education, Government of India. Data Capturing System submissions, "Total Actual Student Strength" tables, 2018 to 2026.

[2] All India Survey on Higher Education (AISHE), Final Report 2023-24, Department of Higher Education, Ministry of Education; and the team's own AISHE inclusion study.

[3] Central Educational Institutions (Reservation in Admission) Act, 2006, and subsequent orders on EWS seats.

Attributions

We would like to thank Dr. Rangeet Bhattacharyya and Dr. Rahul Banerjee, for their guidance, the DoFA office for providing us with the necessary details, as well as the institutes for making their data public.

This study was designed and carried out by Dixita Adhikari of iGEM IISER Kolkata 2026.

Appendices

Appendix A. SC+ST+OBC students, % of all UG+PG students, by NIRF year

Institute	2018	2019	2020	2021	2022	2023	2024	2025	2026
Kolkata	–	46.8	47.4	43.8	47.2	46.8	45.4	45.0	47.0
Pune	–	49.5	49.1	48.6	46.5	46.1	45.4	44.6	45.1
Mohali	–	53.0	52.1	52.0	45.1	50.0	48.7	48.2	–
TVM	–	–	50.5	50.7	49.9	49.5	47.1	49.1	50.5
Tirupati	–	–	–	–	–	–	–	51.9	52.9
Berhampur	–	–	–	–	–	–	47.1	48.7	40.3
Bhopal	–	–	–	–	–	–	–	–	48.1
IISc	49.0	–	49.0	41.0	46.0	47.9	47.2	47.6	49.7

NIRF year Y reports academic year (Y−2) to (Y−1). A dash means no file was available. TVM 2019, Mohali 2026 and IISc 2019 were not in the files provided.

Appendix B. One-year moves of more than 3 points

Institute	NIRF years	Change in share (points)	Change in total students
Berhampur	2025 to 2026	−8.4	+183
Kolkata	2020 to 2021	−3.7	+3
Kolkata	2021 to 2022	+3.4	+116
Mohali	2021 to 2022	−6.9	+88
Mohali	2022 to 2023	+5.0	+67
IISc	2020 to 2021	−8.1	+296
IISc	2021 to 2022	+5.1	+204

For a stock of students in 5-year programmes, a move this large in one year would need the incoming cohort to differ sharply from the one leaving. Kolkata 2020 to 2021 is the clearest case: 3 more students in total, but the SC+ST+OBC count fell by 33.

Appendix C. Tests used

Intervals around shares: Wilson 95%. Comparison with 49.5%: exact binomial test. Differences between institutes: chi-square on the latest-year table (Berhampur 2025 in place of 2026: $\chi^2 = 17.9$, $p = 0.006$; without Berhampur: $p = 0.003$). Trends: ordinary least squares on each institute's series against the start year of the data. UG against PG: Fisher's exact test on pooled counts. Home-state link: Spearman rank correlation.